

The Dance School Awards: Industry Award - Dance Teacher of the Year:

Dance Teacher of the Year Application / Nomination Questions.

Please find below 5 questions which we will need you to answer to proceed with your nomination.

Judges will consider:

- Quality and clarity of teaching practice
- Ability to motivate, inspire, and support students
- Awareness of different learning needs and pathways
- Commitment to student wellbeing and safe practice
- Evidence of professional integrity and reliability
- Ongoing professional development
- Positive impact within their school or community
- Commitment to inclusive and respectful teaching practice that supports a diverse range of students
- A clear case for why this teacher stands out this year

Email *

valentineschool@icloud.com

Full Name *

Claire Jiggins

Email *

valentineschool@icloud.com

Phone Number *

07590401534

Dance School Name *

Valentine Theatre School

1. What makes you an exceptional teacher? *

I believe an exceptional teacher is someone who sees the potential in every student, not just the naturally gifted ones. For over 31 years at Valentine Theatre School, I have built a nurturing environment where children feel valued, challenged and inspired to become the very best version of themselves.

My philosophy has always been to develop incredible human beings as well as talented performers. I encourage discipline, resilience, kindness, respect and teamwork alongside technical excellence. Every child is treated as an individual, with lessons tailored to help them overcome personal challenges and achieve goals they may never have thought possible.

I lead by example, bringing passion, commitment and consistency to every class. Whether a student dreams of performing professionally or simply wants to build confidence, I ensure they leave my studio stronger than when they arrived.

2. How do you support and inspire your students? *

Supporting my students goes far beyond teaching dance steps. I create an environment where every child feels safe, encouraged and believed in. I celebrate effort just as much as achievement and help my students understand that success comes from hard work, perseverance and resilience.

I set high standards because I genuinely believe every child is capable of achieving more than they realise. Through encouragement, honest feedback and unwavering support, I help students develop confidence that extends far beyond the dance studio.

This year alone, our students have achieved incredible success nationally and internationally, including representing England at the Global Dance Open Finals and receiving multiple perfect competition scores. However, what makes me proudest is watching children who once lacked confidence become confident young people who support one another, show kindness and carry themselves with pride.

Seeing former students return as teachers, performers and role models is one of the greatest privileges of my career and reminds me why I do what I do.

3. How do you continue to develop professionally? *

After more than three decades in dance education, I still believe learning never stops.

I regularly attend teacher training, workshops and industry events to ensure my knowledge remains current and relevant. I continually review our teaching methods, introduce new training techniques and adapt our programmes to meet the changing needs of today's young dancers.

I also invest heavily in my own school, our staff and our facilities, ensuring our students receive the highest quality training in a positive, safe and professional environment.

Most importantly, I reflect constantly on my own teaching. Every competition, examination and performance is an opportunity to evaluate what worked well and where we can improve. I never believe I have finished learning, and I hope that attitude inspires my students to adopt the same mindset.

4. What impact have you had in the last year? *

The last year has been one of the most successful in Valentine Theatre School's history.

Our students have achieved outstanding examination results, numerous national titles, international finals and multiple perfect competition scores. Several students represented England at the Global Dance Open Finals, while others secured places at prestigious vocational colleges, associate programmes and professional training opportunities.

Alongside competitive success, we have continued to grow our school community, introducing new programmes, supporting families and providing opportunities for children of all abilities to enjoy dance.

The greatest impact, however, cannot be measured by medals or trophies. It is reflected in the confidence our students gain, the friendships they build, the resilience they develop and the life skills they carry with them long after they leave our studio. Watching children flourish both on and off the stage is the achievement I value most.

5. Why should you be recognised now? *

After dedicating more than 31 years to teaching, mentoring and inspiring young people, I remain as passionate today as I was when I opened Valentine Theatre School in 1995.

This recognition is not simply about competition success—it represents decades of commitment, countless hours of dedication and an unwavering belief in every child who walks through our doors.

I have devoted my career to creating opportunities, raising standards and building a school where children feel they belong, where they are encouraged to dream big and where they learn that hard work and kindness go hand in hand.

If recognised, I hope this award would not only celebrate my own journey but also shine a light on every student, family and member of staff who has been part of Valentine Theatre School. Their achievements are my greatest accomplishment, and it is a privilege to play a small part in helping shape their futures.

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